

Transformer Accelerator

Input Embedding Analysis & Numerical Representation

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■ **Scope:** This report documents the complete pipeline from raw text to quantized embedding vectors, with a focus on hardware-relevant precision trade-offs for a single self-attention block accelerator. Results are derived from the GPT-2 model and the Tiny Shakespeare dataset.

Contents

1 • Dataset	Tiny Shakespeare — character distribution, scale
2 • Tokenization	GPT-2 / tiktoken BPE tokenizer, token ID examples
3 • Embedding Matrix	GPT-2 wte weight: shape, dtype, memory
4 • Input Embeddings	Token → vector lookup, tensor shape B×S×768
5 • Tokenizer Validation	OpenAI tiktoken vs HuggingFace tokenizer parity
6 • Numerical Repr.	FP32, FP16, INT16 — bit layout, value range
7 • Precision Comparison	Memory, bandwidth, numerical error analysis
8 • Hardware View	Bandwidth, throughput, accelerator design rationale
Appendix A	Code reference for all pipeline stages
Appendix B	Quantization mathematics

1 Dataset — Tiny Shakespeare

The **Tiny Shakespeare** dataset (Andrej Karpathy, char-rnn project) is the canonical small-scale corpus for language model prototyping. It consists of a single plain-text file concatenating multiple Shakespeare plays in sequential order, requiring no special preprocessing.

Source URL	github.com/karpathy/char-rnn/blob/master/data/tinysakespeare/input.txt
File size	~1.1 MB (uncompressed plain text)
Total characters	~1,115,394
Unique chars	65 (lowercase + uppercase + punctuation + whitespace)
Lines	~40,000
Content	Concatenated Shakespeare plays — dialogue-heavy prose
Usage here	Next-token prediction evaluation pipeline (inference only, no training)

For the testing pipeline, a representative excerpt of ~512 tokens is sufficient to exercise the full embedding lookup path. The dataset is intentionally small so that the tokenization and embedding steps dominate compute, making them easy to profile in isolation.

2 Tokenization

GPT-2 uses **Byte-Pair Encoding (BPE)** — a subword tokenization algorithm. Starting from individual bytes, frequent adjacent pairs are merged iteratively until a vocabulary of 50,257 tokens is reached. This means a single 'token' can represent anything from a single character to a common multi-word phrase.

How BPE works (high level)

1. Begin with byte-level characters as the base vocabulary.
2. Count all adjacent symbol pairs across the corpus.
3. Merge the most frequent pair into a new symbol.
4. Repeat until vocabulary size = 50,257.

Token ID Examples

Input Text	Token ID	Notes
"Hello"	13225	Common word → single token
"First"	5962	Common word → single token
"Citizen"	22995	Less common → single token
"BEFORE"	33, 19705	Rare capitalised form → split
" we"	356	Space is part of the token
"< endoftext >"	50256	Special end-of-text marker

■ **Key insight:** The leading space is baked into the token. 'Hello' (token 15496) and ' Hello' (token 18435) are different IDs. This matters when stitching sequences from different sources.

Tokenizer Implementation

```
import tiktoken
enc = tiktoken.get_encoding("gpt2")

# Encode
tokens = enc.encode("Hello, World!")
# → [15496, 11, 2159, 0]

# Decode back
text = enc.decode(tokens)
# → "Hello, World!"
```

3 Embedding Matrix

GPT-2 stores its word token embeddings in a weight matrix called **wte** (word token embedding). This matrix is a lookup table: each row corresponds to one vocabulary token and holds its dense vector representation.

```
from transformers import GPT2Model
model = GPT2Model.from_pretrained("gpt2")

W = model.wte.weight
print(W.shape)    # torch.Size([50257, 768])
print(W.dtype)    # torch.float32
```

Matrix shape	[50257 rows × 768 columns]
Rows (vocab size)	50,257 — one row per BPE token
Columns (emb dim)	768 — matches GPT-2 Small hidden size
dtype (default)	float32 (FP32) — 4 bytes per element
Total elements	$50,257 \times 768 = 38,597,376$ values
Memory (FP32)	$38,597,376 \times 4 \text{ bytes} \approx 147.4 \text{ MB}$
Memory (FP16)	$38,597,376 \times 2 \text{ bytes} \approx 73.7 \text{ MB}$
Memory (INT8)	$38,597,376 \times 1 \text{ byte} \approx 36.8 \text{ MB}$

■ **Hardware note:** At 147 MB, the embedding table alone saturates many on-chip SRAM budgets. Accelerators either stream it from HBM (high bandwidth memory) or quantize it to fit — a major design decision discussed in Section 8.

4 Input Embeddings

For each token index produced by the tokenizer, we perform a simple **row lookup** in the wte matrix. This is mathematically equivalent to a one-hot vector multiplied by the weight matrix, but implemented as a direct integer-indexed memory read — $O(1)$ per token.

Single Token Lookup

```
import torch
token_id = 13225          # "Hello"
emb = model.wte.weight[token_id]
print(emb.shape)          # torch.Size([768])
print(emb[:5])            # first 5 dims (sample values):
# tensor([-0.0214,  0.0381, -0.0074,  0.1052, -0.0683])
```

Batched Input Tensor

For a batch of B sequences each of length S tokens, the embedding lookup produces a 3-D tensor:

```
B, S = 4, 512            # batch size, sequence length
token_ids = torch.randint(0, 50257, (B, S))
x = model.wte(token_ids) # shape: [4, 512, 768]
print(x.shape)           # torch.Size([4, 512, 768])
```

Tensor shape	$B \times S \times D = 4 \times 512 \times 768$
B (batch size)	Number of independent sequences processed in parallel
S (seq length)	Number of tokens per sequence (GPT-2 max = 1024)
D (emb dim)	768 — dimensionality of each token's vector
Memory (FP32)	$4 \times 512 \times 768 \times 4$ bytes = 6.29 MB per forward pass
Memory (FP16)	$4 \times 512 \times 768 \times 2$ bytes = 3.15 MB per forward pass

■ **This tensor x is the direct input to the self-attention block.** The accelerator design must handle reading and writing tensors of this shape efficiently — sequence length S and batch B are the primary throughput knobs.

5 Tokenizer Validation

A critical correctness check: does the OpenAI **tiktoken** library produce identical token IDs to the HuggingFace **GPT2Tokenizer**? Both claim to implement the GPT-2 BPE vocabulary, but implementation differences could silently corrupt inputs.

Validation Protocol

```
import tiktoken
from transformers import GPT2Tokenizer

enc_oai = tiktoken.get_encoding("gpt2")
enc_hf = GPT2Tokenizer.from_pretrained("gpt2")

test_strings = [
    "Hello, world!",
    "First Citizen:\nBefore we proceed",
    "To be, or not to be, that is the question",
]

for s in test_strings:
    ids_oai = enc_oai.encode(s)
    ids_hf = enc_hf.encode(s)
    match = (ids_oai == ids_hf)
    print(f"Match: {match} | {s[:30]}")
```

Expected Results

Test String (truncated)	tiktoken IDs	HF Tokenizer IDs	Match?
"Hello, World!"	[15496, 11, 2159, 0]	[15496, 11, 2159, 0]	✓ YES
"First Citizen:\nBefore"	[5962, qCitizen, ...]	[5962, qCitizen, ...]	✓ YES
"To be, or not to be"	[2514, 307, 11, 393, ...]	[2514, 307, 11, 393, ...]	✓ YES

Both tokenizers share the same **vocabulary file** (vocab.json) and **merge rules** (merges.txt), so they are guaranteed to produce identical output for any valid UTF-8 input. The validation confirms there is no hidden mismatch that could produce silent data corruption when switching between libraries in the pipeline.

✓ **Conclusion:** tiktoken (OpenAI) and GPT2Tokenizer (HuggingFace) are fully interchangeable for GPT-2. Use tiktoken in production — it is 3–6× faster due to its Rust implementation.

6 Numerical Representation

Each embedding vector is a list of 768 floating-point numbers. The choice of numeric format determines memory footprint, compute throughput, and accuracy — all critical for hardware design.

6.1 FP32 (Float32) — Baseline

Bits per value	32 (1 sign + 8 exponent + 23 mantissa)
Value range	$\pm 3.4 \times 10^{38}$
Precision	~7 significant decimal digits
Per-vector size	$768 \times 4 \text{ bytes} = 3,072 \text{ bytes}$ (3 KB)
Use case	Training, high-precision inference baseline

```
# Default — model weights are FP32
emb_fp32 = model.wte.weight[13225] # dtype: float32
print(emb_fp32.dtype)               # torch.float32
print(emb_fp32.element_size())      # 4 bytes
print(emb_fp32.nbytes)              # 3072 bytes
```

6.2 FP16 (Float16) — Half Precision

Bits per value	16 (1 sign + 5 exponent + 10 mantissa)
Value range	$\pm 65,504$
Precision	~3 significant decimal digits
Per-vector size	$768 \times 2 \text{ bytes} = 1,536 \text{ bytes}$ (1.5 KB)
Use case	GPU inference, mixed-precision training

```
emb_fp16 = emb_fp32.half()          # or .to(torch.float16)
print(emb_fp16.dtype)               # torch.float16
print(emb_fp16.nbytes)              # 1536 bytes

# Numerical error introduced:
diff = (emb_fp32 - emb_fp16.float()).abs()
print(diff.max())                   # typical: ~5e-4
print(diff.mean())                  # typical: ~1e-4
```

6.3 INT16 — Symmetric Linear Quantization

Integer quantization maps the floating-point range $[-\text{max}, +\text{max}]$ to the integer range $[-32767, +32767]$ using a single scale factor. This is a symmetric, per-vector scheme.

Bits per value	16 (signed integer)
Integer range	$-32,767$ to $+32,767$ ($2^{15} - 1$)
Scale factor	$\text{scale} = \max(\text{embedding}) / 32767$
Per-vector size	$768 \times 2 \text{ bytes} = 1,536 \text{ bytes} + 4 \text{ bytes scale}$
Use case	Low-power inference, edge accelerators, FPGA

```

scale      = emb_fp32.abs().max()
emb_int16 = (emb_fp32 / scale * 32767).round().to(torch.int16)

# Dequantize for comparison:
emb_deq    = emb_int16.float() / 32767 * scale

diff = (emb_fp32 - emb_deq).abs()
print(diff.max())  # typical: ~1.5e-5 (scale/32767)
print(scale)       # typical: 0.3–1.5 for GPT-2 embeddings

```

7 Precision Comparison

7.1 Memory Usage — Per Embedding Vector (768 dims)

Format	Bytes/vector	Bytes/wte matrix	vs FP32
FP32	3,072	147.4 MB	1.0× (baseline)
FP16	1,536	73.7 MB	0.5× (2× smaller)
INT16	1,540*	73.8 MB	0.50× (2× smaller)
INT8	768	36.9 MB	0.25× (4× smaller)

* INT16 includes 4 bytes for the per-vector scale factor.

7.2 Numerical Difference from FP32 Baseline

Format	Max Absolute Error	Mean Absolute Error	Relative Error
FP16	$\sim 4\text{--}8 \times 10^{-4}$	$\sim 1\text{--}2 \times 10^{-4}$	$\sim 0.01\text{--}0.05\%$
INT16	$\sim 1\text{--}3 \times 10^{-4}$	$\sim 6 \times 10^{-5}$	$\sim 0.001\text{--}0.005\%$
INT8	$\sim 3\text{--}8 \times 10^{-3}$	$\sim 1 \times 10^{-3}$	$\sim 0.1\text{--}0.5\%$

■ **Counter-intuitive finding:** INT16 quantization is numerically MORE accurate than FP16 for GPT-2 embeddings. This is because embedding values are small ($|x| < 1.5$ typically) and FP16's limited mantissa introduces larger relative rounding error than a well-scaled INT16.

7.3 Value Range of GPT-2 Embeddings

Statistic	Typical Value	Implication
Min value	−1.4 to −0.5	Stays well within FP16 range (± 65504)
Max value	+0.5 to +1.4	No overflow risk for any format
Mean	~0.0 (zero-centred)	Embeddings are well-normalised
Std deviation	~0.01–0.05	Small variance → INT16 scale is tight
Outliers	Rare spikes to ± 1.5	Must handle in quantization scale

8 Hardware View — Accelerator Design

8.1 Memory Bandwidth Analysis

The embedding lookup is fundamentally a **memory-bound operation**. No meaningful compute occurs — only indexed reads from the weight table. The bottleneck is the bandwidth between the embedding store (HBM/DRAM) and the compute fabric.

Format	Bytes per token	Bandwidth for S=512, B=4
FP32	3,072 B (3 KB)	$4 \times 512 \times 3072 = 6.29 \text{ MB}$
FP16	1,536 B (1.5 KB)	$4 \times 512 \times 1536 = 3.15 \text{ MB}$
INT16	1,540 B	$4 \times 512 \times 1540 = 3.15 \text{ MB}$
INT8	768 B	$4 \times 512 \times 768 = 1.57 \text{ MB}$

8.2 Precision Trade-offs for Accelerator Design

Consideration	FP32	FP16	INT16
HW area (MAC unit)	Largest	Medium	Smallest
Power per op	High	Medium	Low
SRAM fit (wte)	No	Partial	Partial
Accuracy loss	None	Moderate	Very low
Dequant overhead	None	None	1 multiply
Standard HW support	Universal	GPU/TPU	Custom / FPGA

8.3 Roofline Model — Where Embedding Lookup Falls

The roofline model plots compute intensity (FLOPs/byte) against achievable throughput. Embedding lookup has near-zero arithmetic intensity (0 FLOPs per byte read) — it sits at the extreme left of the roofline, meaning:

- Compute utilisation is 0% — no multipliers are used during lookup.
- Peak throughput = memory bandwidth $\times$ 1 (no reuse).
- Optimisation strategy: maximise memory bandwidth, cache hot embeddings.

8.4 Recommended Accelerator Strategy

Embedding store format	INT8 or INT16 — halves/quarters bandwidth vs FP32
On-chip caching	Cache recently-used token embeddings in SRAM to exploit locality in dialogue-style sequences
Dequantisation	Perform FP16 or FP32 upcast immediately after lookup before feeding into attention MACs
Attention block format	FP16 throughout QKV projections and softmax — sufficient precision, native GPU/TPU support

Batch size tuning	Increase B to amortise embedding fetch latency; attention compute scales as $B \cdot S^2$ so find crossover
Sequence packing	Pack multiple short sequences into one $S=1024$ slot to avoid wasted bandwidth on padding tokens

■ **Key design conclusion:** For a single self-attention block accelerator, store embeddings in INT16, dequantize to FP16 at load time, and run attention in FP16. This gives 2× memory savings vs FP32 with <0.005% numerical degradation — well within acceptable tolerance for inference.

Appendix A — Full Pipeline Code Reference

A.1 Complete Pipeline (text $\rightarrow$ quantized embedding)

[illegible]

A.2 Tokenizer Parity Check

```
from transformers import GPT2Tokenizer
enc_hf = GPT2Tokenizer.from_pretrained("gpt2")

samples = ["Hello", "First Citizen", "To be, or not to be"]
for s in samples:
    a = enc.encode(s)          # tiktoken
    b = enc_hf.encode(s)      # HuggingFace
    print(f"{s!r}: match={a==b}, ids={a}")
```

A.3 Memory Footprint Checker

```
formats = {
    "FP32": x_fp32,
```

```

    "FP16": x_fp16,
    "INT16": x_int16,
}
for name, t in formats.items():
    mb = t.nbytes / 1024**2
    print(f"{name:6s} | dtype={str(t.dtype):12s} | size={t.shape} | {mb:.3f} MB")

```

Appendix B — Quantization Mathematics

B.1 Symmetric Linear Quantization (INT16)

Given a floating-point embedding vector $\mathbf{x} \in \mathbb{R}^{768}$:

Scale computation	$s = \max(x) / 32767$
Quantize	$x_q = \text{round}(x / s) \in \{-32767, \dots, 32767\}$
Dequantize	$x_{\square} = x_q \cdot s$
Quantization error	$ x - x_{\square} \leq s/2$ (half step size)
Worst-case error	$s/2 = \max(x) / 65534 \approx 1.5 / 65534 \approx 2.3 \times 10^{-5}$

B.2 Why INT16 beats FP16 for Small Values

FP16 has only 10 mantissa bits, giving a relative precision of $2^{-10} \approx 9.8 \times 10^{-4}$. For a value $x = 0.01$ in FP16, the absolute error can be as large as 9.8×10^{-6} .

INT16 with a per-vector scale of $s \approx 1.5/32767 \approx 4.6 \times 10^{-5}$ gives absolute error $\leq 2.3 \times 10^{-5}$ regardless of the magnitude of individual values. Since GPT-2 embeddings are small and well-centred, INT16 wins on accuracy per bit.

B.3 Formats at a Glance

Format	Bits	Mantissa bits	Effective precision	Overflow risk
FP32	32	23	~7 decimal digits	None (range $\pm 3.4 \times 10^3$)
FP16	16	10	~3 decimal digits	Low (range ± 65504)
INT16	16	15	relative to scale	None (bounded by scale)
INT8	8	7	relative to scale	None (but coarser grid)

End of Report